

POETRY AND power

EASTERN POETRY

Women have been writing literature in China since about 600 BCE, yet it was not until the 16th century when the number of female poets saw a dramatic increase. This can be in part attributed to the rise in female readership at the time; amongst the Chinese elite, female education became increasingly popular. Their literacy inspired many women, elite and non-elite alike, to think far beyond the confines of the traditional female sphere. Women felt empowered to express themselves in ways they had been unable to before.

Female poets offered fresh and contemporary voices in contrast to the static male classics. Diverse poets, from maids, concubines, and courtesans to hermits and grandmothers wrote of marriage, lost loves, motherhood, adultery, unhappiness, and the banality of the everyday, with varying degrees of desire to incite change.

In spite of this shift, women still faced barriers, and those writing were very aware of the limitations placed on them by society. Many 16th century female poets referenced classical stories, such as that of the 1st-century BCE poet concubine Ban Jieyu, who was replaced by a dancer in the affections of the father of her children, the emperor. The tale

► Japanese wordsmith

This woodcut from the Edo period shows a Japanese courtesan doing calligraphy. The artistic accomplishments of courtesans were admired as well as their beauty.



acted as a bitter reminder that female scholarship still took second place to physical beauty.

Sexual odes

In India during the 8th to 17th centuries, women poets emerged from the *bhakti* movement, which emphasizes an individual's intense devotion to a Hindu god and challenged existing hierarchies, with many poets writing in regional languages. Many *bhakti* poets were women and male poets also wrote from the female perspective. *Bhakti* poetry is usually erotic, with writers using the form to praise their god (who was cast in the role of a husband or lover). The most revered of the *bhakti* women poets is the 15th-century mystic and saint, Mirabai, who composed up to a hundred songs or *bhajans*.

In contrast, in Japan, the activity of female poets (see pp. 58–59) decreased from the 14th century with the rise of poetic forms such as *renku* and *haiku*, which were written in men-only groups and considered too coarse for women. However, in the 17th century, *haiku* came to rely less on obscene references, and the genre became open to female poets via its focus on classical allusion and wordplay.



"UNDER MOONLIT
CURTAINS, AS THE
SONGS SUBSIDE
I SEARCH ..."

LIU RUSHI, CHINESE COURTESAN AND POET